

Business

1. Target recently posted better-than-expected second-quarter sales and raised its full-year outlook. But buried in the results was an unusual boost — which of these gave Target's numbers an extra lift?
 - a. A surge in back-to-school clothing sales
 - b. Tariff refunds from the US government
 - c. A new credit card partnership with Visa
2. China's electric vehicle industry is facing a record wave of recalls this month — not because of faulty batteries or brakes, but because of a design feature borrowed from Tesla. What is it?
 - a. Flush, concealed door handles
 - b. One-pedal regenerative braking
 - c. Panoramic glass roofs
3. Paramount and Warner Bros. Discovery want to merge, but state attorneys general are pursuing an antitrust (competition law) case that has pushed the timeline back to as late as June 2027. Paramount has just asked for something unusual to cover its costs during the wait — what?
 - a. A \$1.88 billion bond from state attorneys general to guarantee against losses from the delay
 - b. A bridging loan from the US Federal Reserve's emergency lending facility
 - c. Permission to sell its streaming rights to a third party while the case proceeds
4. TikTok influencers have recently been spotted tapping a very unconventional object to pay for things in shops. What are some Gen Z consumers now using as a contactless payment device?
 - a. A novelty magic wand
 - b. A customised Stanley Cup tumbler with an embedded chip
 - c. A branded friendship bracelet with NFC technology

Economics

5. UK inflation (the rate at which prices across the economy are rising) jumped to 2.9% in July, a four-month high. The single biggest driver was a sharp rise in household energy costs. How much did the UK energy price cap rise to cause that spike?
 - a. By 6%, reflecting modest increases in global gas markets
 - b. By 13%, the sharpest gas price rise in almost four years
 - c. By 21%, triggered by a new carbon levy on suppliers

6. The US Treasury recently doubled the size of its government debt buyback programme. Debt buybacks involve the government repurchasing its own previously issued bonds from investors. Which of these is NOT a likely reason the Treasury did this?
 - a. To reduce volatility in the bond market as long-term yields (the return investors demand to hold government debt) climbed
 - b. To signal confidence in the government's finances and calm nervous investors
 - c. To increase the amount of money the government can borrow at short notice without Congressional approval
7. South Korea recently sent its first trial container ship through the Arctic Ocean, a route that cuts thousands of kilometres off the journey from Asia to Europe. What is the main reason it is doing this now?
 - a. A new trade deal with Arctic nations opened the route to South Korean vessels for the first time
 - b. Conflict in the Middle East has disrupted traditional shipping lanes through the Suez Canal
 - c. Record Arctic ice melt has made the northern route commercially viable year-round for the first time
8. US cherries are a luxury item in Vietnam, but prices have surged dramatically in recent weeks due to supply constraints and geopolitical tensions. Roughly how much are American cherries selling for per kilogram in Vietnamese markets right now?
 - a. Around \$12 per kg, about the same as premium imported apples
 - b. Around \$20 per kg, similar to high-end Japanese fruit
 - c. Around \$31 per kg, up as much as 95% from a year ago

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of lithium, the metal at the heart of electric vehicle batteries and energy storage?
 - a. Chile
 - b. Australia
 - c. China
10. Which economist, working in 18th-century Scotland, wrote the book now considered the founding text of modern economics, arguing that individual self-interest — not royal decree — drives the wealth of nations?
 - a. David Ricardo
 - b. Adam Smith
 - c. John Stuart Mill

Business

1. Target recently posted better-than-expected second-quarter sales and raised its full-year outlook. But buried in the results was an unusual boost — which of these gave Target's numbers an extra lift?

b. Tariff refunds from the US government helped boost Target's results. The company received money back on import duties it had previously paid, giving earnings a one-off lift alongside genuine sales improvement. It's a reminder that trade policy doesn't just affect prices on shelves — it can also quietly reshape a retailer's bottom line.

2. China's electric vehicle industry is facing a record wave of recalls this month — not because of faulty batteries or brakes, but because of a design feature borrowed from Tesla. What is it?

a. China is banning concealed door handles from 2027, making it the first country to phase out the sleek flush-handle design that Tesla popularised and Chinese EV makers widely copied. The concern is that the handles can be hard to find in an emergency. The recall affects vehicles across multiple brands and is already being described as the largest of its kind in the country's automotive history.

3. Paramount and Warner Bros. Discovery want to merge, but state attorneys general are pursuing an antitrust (competition law) case that has pushed the timeline back to as late as June 2027. Paramount has just asked for something unusual to cover its costs during the wait — what?

a. Paramount is seeking a \$1.88 billion bond from the state attorneys general whose antitrust challenge caused the delay. The logic: if regulators force a company to wait, they should post security against the costs that wait creates. It's an unusual move that reflects how expensive merger limbo can be — advisers, financing, and management attention all carry a price tag that compounds over months.

4. TikTok influencers have recently been spotted tapping a very unconventional object to pay for things in shops. What are some Gen Z consumers now using as a contactless payment device?

a. Magic wand-shaped tap-to-pay devices are having a moment on TikTok, with influencers turning the checkout into a style statement. The wands use the same NFC (near-field communication) chip technology as a standard contactless card — they just look considerably more whimsical. It's part of a broader trend of embedding payment tech into jewellery, keyrings, and accessories aimed at Gen Z shoppers.

Economics

5. UK inflation (the rate at which prices across the economy are rising) jumped to 2.9% in July, a four-month high. The single biggest driver was a sharp rise in household energy costs. How much did the UK energy price cap rise to cause that spike?

b. The UK energy price cap rose by 13% in July, pushing gas prices to their highest in nearly four years and dragging overall inflation up to 2.9%. The price cap sets the maximum unit rate suppliers can charge households — when it rises, millions of bills go up simultaneously, making it one of the most powerful single levers in the UK inflation data. The Bank of England's target is 2%.

6. The US Treasury recently doubled the size of its government debt buyback programme. Debt buybacks involve the government repurchasing its own previously issued bonds from investors. Which of these is NOT a likely reason the Treasury did this?

c. Bypassing Congressional borrowing limits is not the goal here. The Treasury doubled its buybacks primarily to smooth the bond market, where long-term yields had been climbing and liquidity (the ease of buying and selling) had grown patchy. By buying back older bonds, the Treasury reduces the supply investors must absorb and can help anchor yields. It's a technical tool, but in a jittery market it sends a reassuring signal.

7. South Korea recently sent its first trial container ship through the Arctic Ocean, a route that cuts thousands of kilometres off the journey from Asia to Europe. What is the main reason it is doing this now?

b. The Middle East conflict has made the Suez Canal route — the standard path from Asia to Europe — riskier and more expensive, pushing shippers to explore alternatives. The Arctic route can shave roughly 7,000 kilometres off the journey compared to going via Suez. Environmental groups have raised concerns that increased Arctic shipping could accelerate ice melt, creating a feedback loop that opens the route further.

8. US cherries are a luxury item in Vietnam, but prices have surged dramatically in recent weeks due to supply constraints and geopolitical tensions. Roughly how much are American cherries selling for per kilogram in Vietnamese markets right now?

c. US cherries are fetching around \$30–31 per kilogram in Vietnam, nearly double what they cost a year ago. The spike reflects both tighter US supply and the ripple effects of trade tensions making American agricultural exports more expensive to source. It's a vivid example of how geopolitics can show up in something as everyday as a bowl of fruit — and why imported food prices often move faster than local inflation figures suggest.

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of lithium, the metal at the heart of electric vehicle batteries and energy storage?

b. Australia is the world's largest lithium producer by volume, extracting the metal primarily from hard-rock spodumene mines in Western Australia. Chile holds the largest known reserves and dominates brine-based production, while China controls most of the world's lithium refining capacity. Between the three, they account for the overwhelming majority of the global lithium supply chain.

10. Which economist, working in 18th-century Scotland, wrote the book now considered the founding text of modern economics, arguing that individual self-interest — not royal decree — drives the wealth of nations?

b. Adam Smith published 'The Wealth of Nations' in 1776, the same year as the American Declaration of Independence. Smith argued that individuals pursuing their own interests are guided, as if by an 'invisible hand', to benefit society as a whole — a radical idea at a time when governments controlled most trade. The book laid the intellectual groundwork for free markets and is still cited in economic debates today.